

1890–1899

HIGH RUFFS AND WASP WAISTS

Womenswear in the last decade of the Victorian era was characterized by high collars, held in place by collar stays, and stiff steel boning in long-line bodices and corsets. Mid decade, tiny wasp waists were emphasized by the most enormous sleeves and pyramid skirts with smooth fronts, which had pleating concentrated at centre back. In mainstream fashions, the ruff, corseting, padded sleeves, and cone-shaped skirts consciously recalled Elizabethan fin-de-siècle styling. Ball dresses were décolleté (had a low neckline), but for daywear barely any flesh was revealed below chin level. Dark colours persisted but were challenged by a lighter palette anticipating Edwardian pinks and creams. Coloured stockings and high heels were popular. The use of exotic bird feathers and even whole birds on hats had become such an issue that the Royal Society for the Protection of Birds was founded, to campaign against any but ostrich feathers being used in future.

CAPES

On trend: red and black



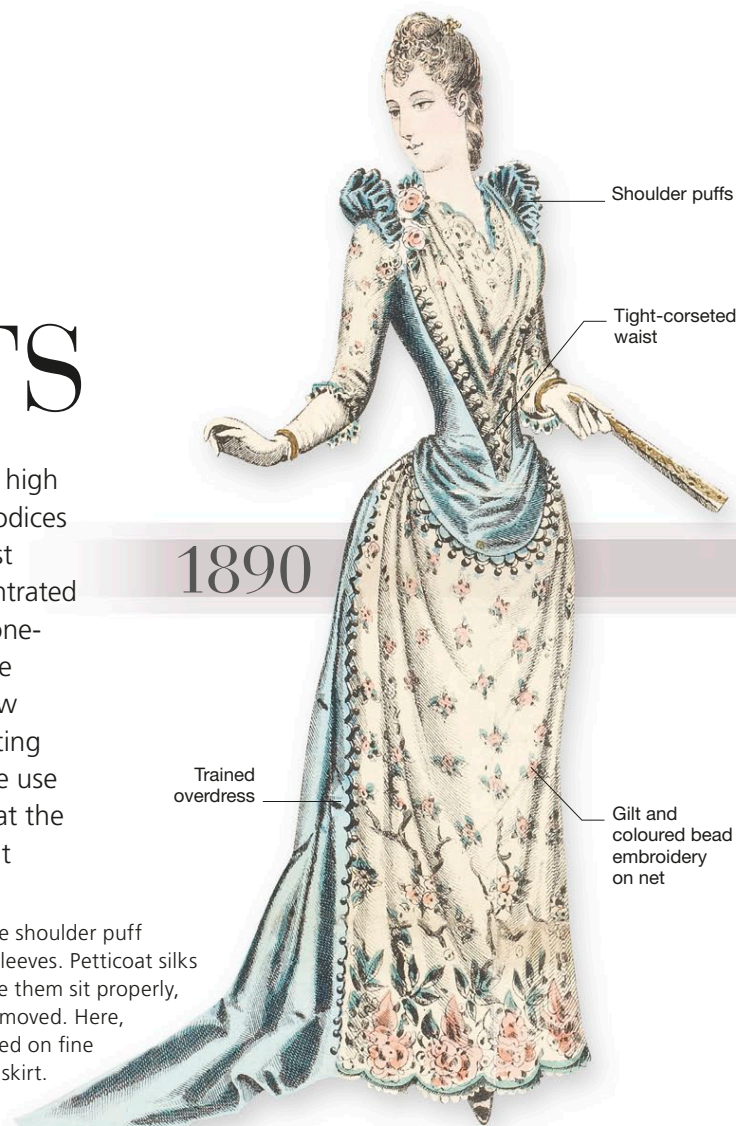
Moleskin and feathers



Satin and velvet

Short, boxy capes replaced the 1880s dolman capes, once the bustle had disappeared. Silk brocade was popular for opera wear, to cover décolletage, and might be trimmed with jet, French jet (glass), lace, appliqué, braid, fur, or feathers. For daywear, woollen cloth capes trimmed with braid or appliqué detail co-existed alongside travelling jackets and full-length coats. They were certainly easier to wear over the large, leg-of-mutton sleeves of 1893–96. Black and red were the most fashionable colours.

Dressed for evening The shoulder puff heralded a new focus on sleeves. Petticoat silks were tin-weighted to make them sit properly, and rustled as the wearer moved. Here, delicate embroidery, worked on fine net or gauze, overlays the skirt.



1890

Shoulder puffs

Tight-corseted waist

Trained overdress

Gilt and coloured bead embroidery on net

Leg-of-mutton sleeves

Crescent "Diana" headdress



Wasp waist

1895

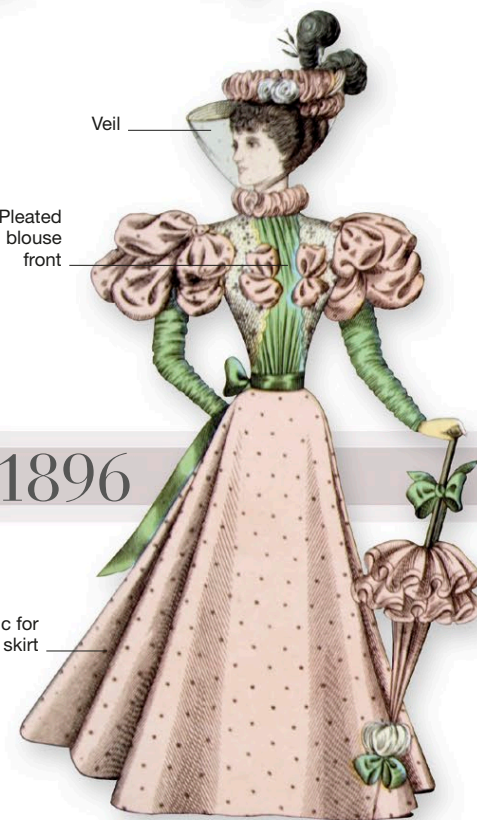
Hourglass shape Warp-printed chine silk gives this outfit a particular lustre. Enormous, leg-of-mutton sleeves, bows along skirt seams, a defined V shaping to the bodice, and "Elizabethan" ruff typify the fin-de-siècle style.

Veil

Pleated blouse front

1896

Spotted fabric for panelled skirt



Summer blouse and skirt This veiled hat would have been secured with decorative hatpins that pierced into the top knot of swept-up hair. The ruff encouraged good deportment, always required in Victorian women.